in the Administration's performance. It is a mark of both the man and the times that five years later, recording his memoir of the crisis, he came to wonder about the question: "What, if any, circumstance or justification gives this government or any government the moral right to bring its people and possibly all people under the shadow of nuclear destruction?"

That the United States and Soviet Union could engage in a nuclear war which would effectively destroy both societies (and much of the rest of the world) is a plain but incredible fact about contemporary life. We are now twenty-six years into the nuclear age. For more than a decade, the Soviet Union has been capable of destroying millions of Americans. Yet no war has come. Today who can believe that such a war could come?

How does our nuclear era differ from previous periods? Students of international politics have identified three qualitatively new aspects of the threat and use of force in an era of thermonuclear weapons and ballistic missiles. First, the magnitude of destructive power of thermonuclear weapons is unparalleled. Previously, men have destroyed men by bullets and bombs. Today, the explosive power of a single thermonuclear bomb exceeds the total explosive power of all bombs used in all wars of the past, including those of this century. Second, the suddenness and swiftness with which mass destruction can be inflicted has no precedent. Surprise attacks are not new. But today no point on the globe lies more than minutes away from annihilation by a ballistic missile. Third, because of the first two factors, the meaning has been taken out of "victory" in war. As recently as 1945, victory consisted of disarming the enemy, after which the victor could determine the fate of the vanquished. Today, it is not necessary to defeat a nation's armies before disposing of its citizens. The use of arms and soldiers to prevent occupation of one's country is no longer sufficient to guarantee its citizens against destruction.

In personal and societal terms, what these new conditions mean was stated starkly by one of the participants in the missile crisis, Robert McNamara. The Secretary of Defense testified to Congress in 1964: "In the first hour [of all-out nuclear war] one hundred million Americans and one hundred million Russians would be killed."

Such hard physical facts are difficult to accept. But even less acceptable, given these conditions, is that nations could *choose* war. The United States and the Soviet Union now live in a world of "mutual superiority," that is, mutual capability to do unacceptable damage to the other (even after having been struck first). Under such conditions, could